



The Charge, Line by Line

What we actually tell a new brother

RITUAL

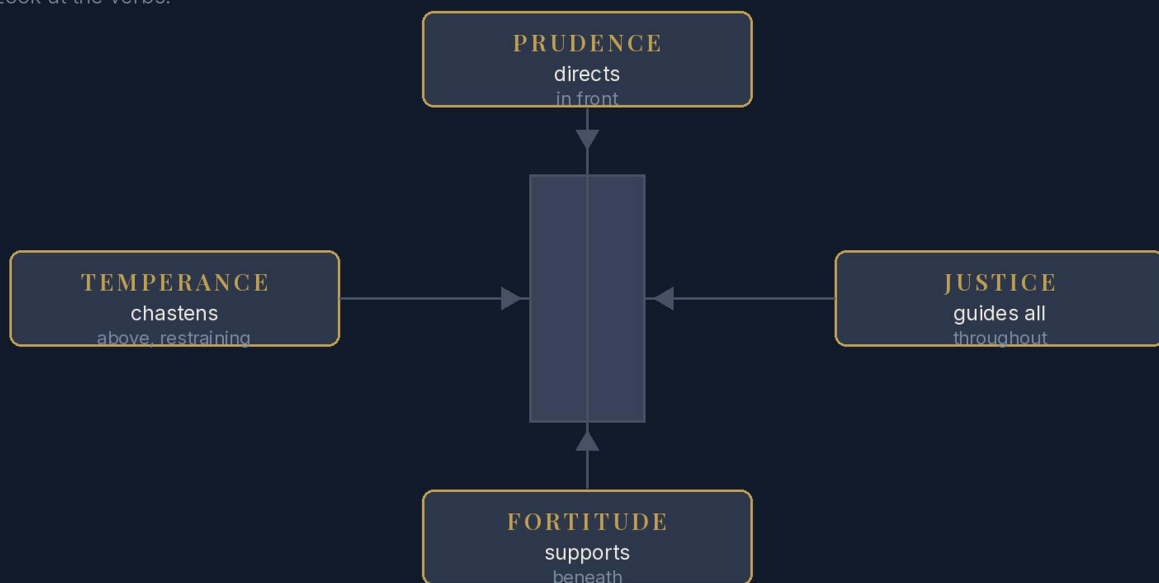
Everyone has heard it. Almost nobody has read it. Taken at walking pace it turns out to be a complete statement of what the Craft believes a man should be — and one of the best pieces of prose in the English ritual.

ON THE TABLE

The Charge after Initiation, read slowly

A MAN, DESCRIBED AS A STRUCTURE

Let prudence direct you, temperance chasten you, fortitude support you, and justice be the guide of all your actions. Look at the verbs.



Not a list of nice qualities. A member at every bearing point.

Diagram drawn for The Vulcan Papers.

HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
2:00	Part One: the shape of it
5:00	Part Two: the three great duties
9:00	Part Three: the cardinal virtues
12:00	Part Four: as a citizen
15:00	Part Five: the last instruction
18:00	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 It runs God, neighbour, self, state — and puts the Craft fifth out of five.
- 2 Prudence directs, temperance chastens, fortitude supports, justice guides all.
- 3 It ends by requiring a daily advancement in masonic knowledge. That is why this series exists.

IF YOU ARE ASKED



THE CHARGE, LINE BY LINE

Is the Charge secret?

No. It has been published for two centuries and appears in the printed rituals.

How old is it?

It reached substantially its present form in the eighteenth century and was settled at the Union. Its ancestry runs back to the Old Charges.

Why does duty to self come third?

Because a man must be in working order to discharge the other two. It is maintenance, not indulgence.

Why the emphasis on obedience to the state?

Partly defensive — masonry grew up under official suspicion across Europe — and partly meant.

What is "daily advancement"?

The closing instruction of the Charge, and the reason lodges deliver papers at all.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual (Lewis Masonic) — the Charge after Initiation, as worked in England
- Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723 — the Charges from which it descends
- The Old Charges (Regius, c.1390; Cooke, c.1410) — the ancestry of the form
- Colin Dyer, Symbolism in Craft Freemasonry
- Papers Seven and Eleven in this series, for the religious and historical background

The Charge is published, and has been for two centuries. This paper reads it as a piece of writing. It touches nothing that is not in print.

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

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